

According to a study from Spectrem Group's 2017 Market Insights Report, there are almost 11 million millionaires in the United States today.<sup>[1](#)</sup> That's more millionaires than ever before. That same report, though, shows the number of people living paycheck to paycheck is on the rise, with one in three unable to cover a \$2,000 emergency with cash. You may be surprised to learn that even some affluent two-income households are struggling to make ends meet too. What's going on here? How are there more millionaires than ever before *and* more people living paycheck to paycheck than ever before *at the same time*? What do the millionaires do that everyone else doesn't? That's exactly what we set out to discover.

The Ramsey Solutions research team and I recently completed the largest, most comprehensive research study of millionaires in history. The last major research project involving millionaires was Thomas Stanley and William Danko's landmark book *The Millionaire Next Door*, which was originally printed in 1996. Stanley and Danko believed that everyday people—men and women just like you and me—could become millionaires. They put a spotlight on the typical American millionaire, and they realized millionaires lived pretty mundane lives. These were men and women who most people would never assume to be wealthy. *The Millionaire Next Door* radically reshaped our understanding of what millionaires look like and how they behave, and my research team and I wanted to know if those findings still rang true more than twenty years later.

Over the past year, we have surveyed and/or interviewed over 10,000 American millionaires. We targeted people with a net worth of more than \$1 million, meaning the total of all their assets, bank accounts, and investments (minus any debts) totals \$1 million or more. Most of them (89%) have a net worth between \$1 million and \$5 million. The rest have a net worth well over the \$5 million mark. We asked this group everything we could think of to help us get a crystal-clear picture of who they were, how they acted, where they lived, what they did for a living, where their money came from, how long it took them to hit millionaire status, and what their wealth meant to them.

In the first half of this book, we will examine the most common myths that are perpetuated in our society about the wealthy. We actually asked millionaires to tell us what objections they've heard over the years and why